Jet Lag Pro: A Mobile Platform for Evaluating Chronoacupuncture as a Tool for Jet Lag Management

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Abstract

Background: Jet lag is common among long-haul travelers, and existing strategies (light exposure, melatonin, behavioral scheduling) show inconsistent real-world effectiveness. Non-photic zeitgebers can influence circadian phase; repeated timed somatosensory stimulation aligned with destination time has been proposed as a potential cue but not quantitatively evaluated in travelers.

Objective: To assess whether adherence to a structured chronoacupressure protocol delivered via a mobile app is associated with lower jet lag symptom severity across typical long-haul travel patterns.

Methods: In a prospective, app-based observational cohort, long-haul travelers used JetLagPro to receive timed prompts for a 12-point acupressure protocol aligned with the destination time zone. After travel, participants completed a jet lag survey based on the core domains of the Liverpool Jet Lag Questionnaire. We compared composite symptom scores across adherence levels and time zones crossed.

Results: *PLACEHOLDER TEXT: Among [N] eligible trips (median [X] time zones, interquartile range [Y–Z]), higher stimulation was significantly associated with lower composite jet lag severity ($p < 0.001$ for trend). Compared with minimal stimulation (0–2 points), high stimulation (9–12 points) was associated with a [Δ]-point lower composite score (95% confidence interval [a–b]), corresponding to an effect size of approximately $d \approx [0.4–0.6]$. Similar patterns were observed across eastward and westward travel and across 6–8 and ≥9 time-zone crossings.*

Conclusions: *PLACEHOLDER TEXT: In real-world long-haul travel, higher adherence to the timed acupressure protocol was consistently associated with meaningfully lower jet lag symptom scores and attenuated symptom escalation with increasing time zones crossed. While causal inference is limited by the non-randomized, self-selected design, the graded dose–response and robustness across sensitivity analyses support timed somatosensory stimulation as a promising, low-risk non-photic cue for jet lag management.*

Significance: This study is the first systematic evaluation of timed somatosensory stimulation (acupressure) as a potential non-photic cue for jet lag in real-world travelers.

Keywords: circadian entrainment, non-photic zeitgeber, jet lag, acupressure, horary points, Traditional Chinese Medicine

Introduction

Jet lag is a common problem for international travelers, arising from misalignment between endogenous circadian rhythms and the destination light–dark cycle.[1] The suprachiasmatic nucleus (SCN) and peripheral clocks re-entrain at different rates; natural adaptation after time-zone travel is roughly one hour per day for eastward travel and slightly faster westward, so that crossing many time zones can mean several days of impaired sleep, alertness, and well-being.

Current strategies to accelerate re-entrainment include timed light exposure, melatonin supplementation, and sleep or meal scheduling. These interventions are supported by phase-response data and are reflected in travel medicine guidelines, but adherence and real-world efficacy are variable. Light must be timed correctly to the destination schedule; melatonin is not equally effective for all individuals or directions of travel; and behavioral scheduling is often difficult to maintain during and immediately after long-haul flights.

Beyond light (the dominant zeitgeber), circadian phase can be shifted by non-photic cues such as exercise timing, meal timing, and behavioral activity.[7] Repeated timed somatosensory stimulation is therefore a plausible candidate to facilitate re-entrainment, although it has not been systematically evaluated in travelers. The present study evaluates whether adherence to a timed acupressure protocol aligned with destination-time windows is associated with reduced jet-lag symptom severity in a prospective, app-based observational cohort.

Circadian Biology: Mechanisms of Internal Clocks

The scientific literature describes how circadian rhythms synchronize physiological processes to a 24-26 hour cycle through the suprachiasmatic nucleus (SCN), a cluster of neurons entrained by light.[2,3] The SCN coordinates peripheral clocks in organs like the liver and heart, which regulate tissue-specific functions including vascular function and blood pressure regulation.[4,5] Core clock genes (Clock, Bmal1, Period, Cryptochrome) drive a molecular feedback loop, producing rhythmic gene expression.[6]

Synchronization is maintained by Zeitgebers, external signals such as light, temperature, activity, and meals.[7]

Jet lag occurs when rapid time zone changes desynchronize these internal clocks (Figure 1). Non-photic zeitgebers—including exercise and feeding time—can influence SCN and peripheral clock phase in animal and human studies, supporting the idea that other timed sensory cues might contribute to re-entrainment.

Timed Acupressure as a Non-Photic Protocol

More than 40 years ago, Khoe[8] and later Amaro[9] proposed that targeted stimulation of acupuncture points during travel could help minimize jet lag by aligning the body with the destination time zone. Their approach drew on Traditional Chinese Medicine (TCM) principles documented as early as the Han Dynasty[10] (200 BCE–200 CE). These texts describe a 24-hour cycle in which specific organs and their associated energy pathways (meridians) show heightened activity during recurring two-hour intervals (see Table 1). Khoe and Amaro focused on a subset of points known as horary points, which correspond to each meridian's elemental properties and are considered most influential during its peak activity window (Figure 2).

A recent review supports the broader concept that acupuncture may influence circadian biology, reporting effects on circadian clock genes, neurotransmitter systems, and sleep–wake regulation (Wu & Zhao, 2024).[11] Although these studies primarily examined points associated with sleep, they suggest that acupuncture may act as a non-photic zeitgeber capable of modulating circadian rhythms.

Although the mechanistic pathways remain under investigation, these findings are consistent with the possibility that temporally targeted somatosensory stimulation may interact with circadian regulatory systems.

The protocol delivers repeated timed somatosensory stimulation aligned with destination local time, potentially acting as a non-photic circadian cue. The stimulation schedule is based on meridian activity windows from Traditional Chinese Medicine (Table 1, Figure 2); acupressure provides a structured delivery system for the cue.

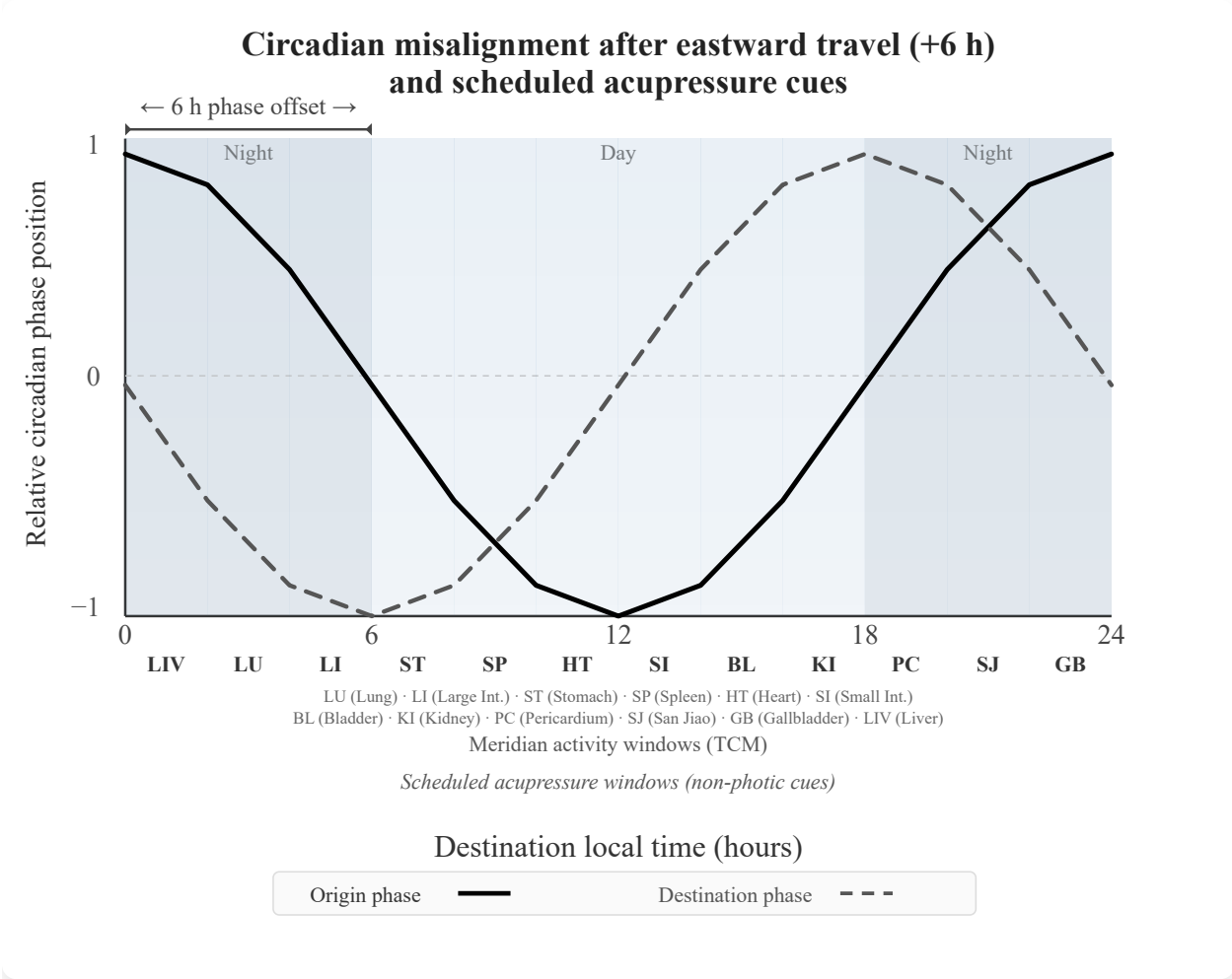


Figure 1. *Conceptual model of chronoacupuncture as a circadian timing cue during transmeridian travel. After eastward travel across time zones, endogenous circadian phase remains aligned with the origin time zone, producing temporary misalignment with the destination light–dark cycle (solid vs dashed curves). The protocol schedules acupressure stimulation during meridian activity windows shifted to destination local time (blue bands). These repeated somatosensory cues may function as non-photic zeitgebers that facilitate circadian realignment.*

Practical Point Substitutions

Classical protocols emphasize the use of horary points. However, early testers traveling in economy-class seating reported that some foot and ankle points were difficult to access because of footwear or limited space. To improve practicality, the protocol was modified by substituting more accessible points along the same active meridian. The rationale is straightforward: stimulating a more accessible point on the active meridian during its designated window is preferable to omitting the meridian entirely.

This pragmatic modification is consistent with broader TCM channel theory, which posits that stimulation anywhere along a meridian during its horary window can influence that channel and its associated organ system.

Although timed acupressure has long been advocated by practitioners for jet lag, it has not been quantitatively evaluated in large cohorts of real-world travelers. This prospective observational cohort study was designed to evaluate whether a time-aligned acupressure protocol shows signals of efficacy in real-world travel conditions. The study is intended as hypothesis-generating, with the goal of informing future randomized trials. We examined whether adherence to the meridian-aligned, time-specific stimulation schedule was associated with reduced jet-lag symptom severity compared with minimal use and historical baseline data.

The present study evaluates whether adherence to a timed acupressure protocol aligned with destination-time meridian windows is associated with reduced jet-lag symptom severity among long-distance travelers. We hypothesized that greater adherence to scheduled stimulation windows would correlate with lower post-travel jet-lag severity, consistent with a dose-response relationship expected for circadian entrainment cues.

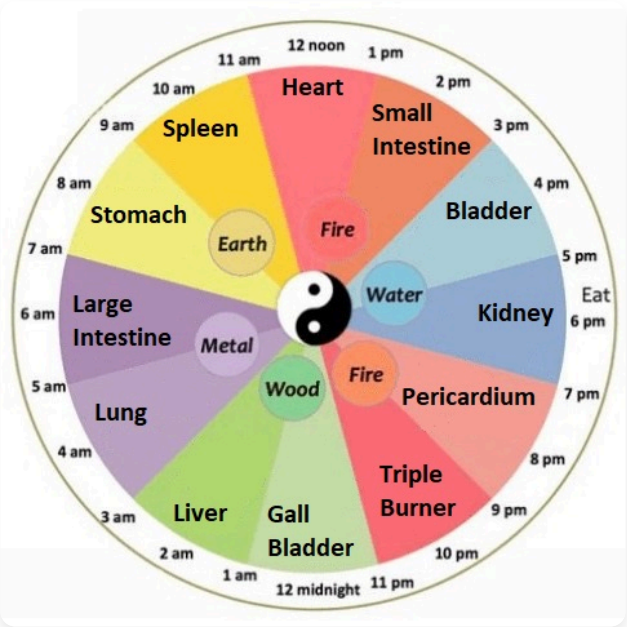


Figure 2: *Chinese Organ Clock Visualization*

Table 1: Chinese Organ Clock Schedule

Time Range	Meridian / Organ System	Active Point
3:00 AM – 5:00 AM	Lung	LU-8
5:00 AM – 7:00 AM	Large Intestine	LI-1
7:00 AM – 9:00 AM	Stomach	ST-36
9:00 AM – 11:00 AM	Spleen	(SP-3) → SP-10*
11:00 AM – 1:00 PM	Heart	HT-8
1:00 PM – 3:00 PM	Small Intestine	SI-5
3:00 PM – 5:00 PM	Bladder	(BL-66) → BL-2*
5:00 PM – 7:00 PM	Kidney	(KI-10) → KI-27*
7:00 PM – 9:00 PM	Pericardium	PC-8
9:00 PM – 11:00 PM	San Jiao (Triple Warmer)	SJ-6
11:00 PM – 1:00 AM	Gallbladder	(GB-41) → GB-20*
1:00 AM – 3:00 AM	Liver	(LIV-1) → LIV-8*

**These 5 points were substituted for improved accessibility in economy class seating.*

Methods

Study design

This is an app-based prospective observational cohort study embedded in the JetLagPro mobile application. The app was freely available to the public without restriction.

Participants

Participants were self-selected travelers who sought and downloaded the app. This population is likely more motivated and health-conscious than the average traveler. While this does introduce a selection bias, it simultaneously enhances external validity for the group most likely to adopt such an intervention in real life.

Intervention protocol

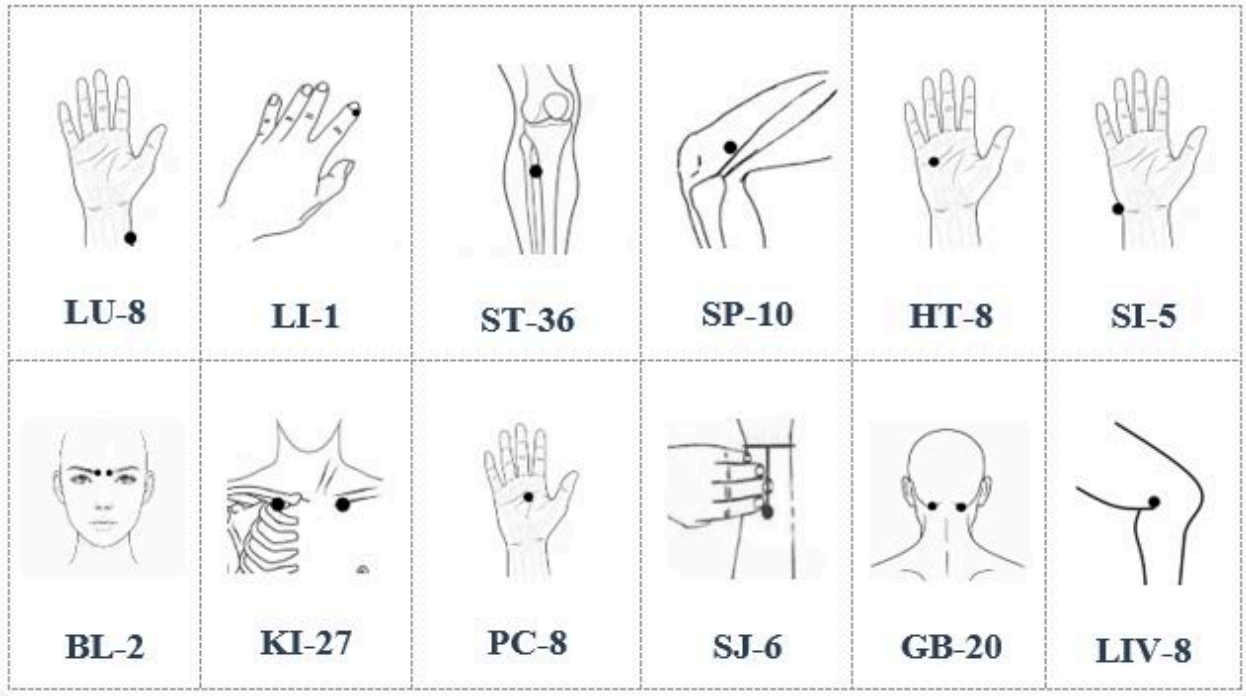
The mobile application provides travelers with timing and instructions to stimulate specific points based on the destination time. Point selection follows the strategic substitutions described in Table 1. (The user can opt for the traditional points via a setting in the app.)

Ideally starting at the airport (or anytime thereafter), travelers select their destination. The app immediately identifies the first active point matching the local time at destination and then schedules a full 24-hour sequence of prompts in two-hour increments. This process is illustrated below.

Steps 1–3: Basic instructions, destination selection, and point stimulation.

Scheduled reminders pop up at appropriate times prompting the traveler to complete a full 24-hour cycle. The reminders are persistent and remain on the traveler's phone (or watch) until clicked. When clicked, the traveler is shown the correct image beside a looping video showing how to stimulate the point on the Points Screen (#3). The watch also provides a "show me" option that displays the point image. Written instructions are provided above and below the phone images.

Point Images



After the trip ends, the app logs trip data to Firebase, including arrival timezone to validate actual travel. One critical data element we store at trip end is the timezone difference between the origin and destination calculated using IANA timezone identifiers. Our application automatically accounts for Daylight Saving Time when calculating timezone offsets using the device's native timezone libraries. However, trips that begin or end during DST transitions may experience ±1 hour variance in reported timezone counts due to the timing of when offsets are captured.

A final step when the trip ends is the scheduling of a notification for 2 days later (short time frame to minimize recall bias) to remind the traveler to complete the website survey. This survey is a streamlined assessment based on the Liverpool Jet Lag Questionnaire's core symptom domains (listed below), using 1-5 severity ranges adapted for real-world mobile use as a single post-travel evaluation.

Outcomes

The post-travel survey is a streamlined assessment based on the Liverpool Jet Lag Questionnaire's core symptom domains, using 1–5 severity ranges adapted for real-world mobile use as a single post-travel evaluation. The survey retains the LJLQ's core validated domains: sleep quality/disturbance, daytime fatigue, concentration difficulties, irritability/motivation, and gastrointestinal function but omits less central items (e.g., detailed appetite or bowel frequency changes) to minimize participant burden. The

survey also includes a single-item chronotype measure: “Which statement best describes your natural sleep preference?” with five options from definitely morning type (“lark”) to definitely evening type (“owl”), as a proxy for morningness–eveningness.[12] Single-item chronotype proxies are widely used in large observational studies when the full Morningness–Eveningness Questionnaire is not feasible.

The primary outcome is a composite jet lag severity score calculated as the mean of the five 1–5 domain ratings. Secondary outcomes are the individual domain scores and the difference between anticipated and actual composite scores (within-subject change).

Data collection

Table 2: Data Collection Categories

Post Travel Survey Questions	Data Reported by the App
User anticipated overall jet lag severity; Actual: Sleep disturbance, Daytime fatigue, Difficulty concentrating, Irritability, Lack of Motivation/energy, Gastrointestinal issues; Natural sleep preference (chronotype: morning/evening type); Age Range	Direction of travel; Number of time zones crossed; Number of points marked as stimulated; Local timezone to validate location; use of traditional or cramped point sets

Primary Research Question

Is adherence to the timed acupressure protocol as directed by the app associated with lower jet lag symptoms compared to minimal or no use?

This study does not include a randomized true control because practical constraints of anonymous volunteer participation precludes randomization or even a no-app sham condition. That is why we resort to a within-subject design where each participant serves as their own control. Participants voluntarily complete surveys that include two separate elements: (1) anticipated symptom severity (based on prior travel experience), and (2) actual post-travel symptom severity as reported after completing their journey. The anticipated-versus-actual comparison is exploratory and subject to recall and expectation bias; the primary analytical strategy relies on between-adherence comparison and external baseline (Waterhouse et al.).

Baseline Data for Time Zones Crossed

Our analysis compares survey results to baseline severity data from Waterhouse et al.'s 2007 comprehensive quantitative assessment of jet lag severity stratified by time zones[1]. That study shows

non-interventional severity falls into the following ranges on a 1-5 severity scale.

- 1-2 time zones: 1.8
- 3-5 time zones: 2.5
- 6-8 time zones: 3.1
- 9+ time zones: 3.6

Stimulation Level Groupings ("adherence level")

Participants are grouped by the number of acupressure points reported by the app as stimulated during travel:

- 0-2 points (no intervention)
- 3-5 points (low stimulation)
- 6-8 points (moderate stimulation)
- 9-12 points (high stimulation)

For each stimulation group, we analyze post-travel symptom severity across different time zone categories to assess how stimulation levels affects the expected symptom increase from crossing more time zones. This grouping provides sufficient sample sizes for statistical analysis while maintaining meaningful intervention categories.

Time Zone Offset and Travel Direction

The app records the time difference (offset) in hours between origin and destination. A positive offset means the body must advance its rhythm (eastward), a negative value means delay (westward). The eastward adjustment typically feels harder than westward. For example, Los Angeles to Sydney is a +19-hour offset, so the app classifies it as eastward even though the flight goes west geographically. For trips over 12 hours the body may adapt the shorter way around the clock, but we use the direct arrival offset for analysis.

Statistical analysis

Covariate selection was guided by a directed acyclic graph (DAG) representing plausible causal relationships between travel characteristics, protocol adherence, and jet-lag outcomes (see project

repository for reproducible figure code). Based on this framework, models adjust for the number of time zones crossed, travel direction (eastward vs westward), and chronotype (five-level morningness–eveningness proxy), which may influence both adherence and symptom severity. We do not adjust for sleep timing or individual symptom domains, as these are likely on the causal path from adherence to overall severity (mediators) and adjusting for them would obscure the total effect of the protocol. Other potential confounders (e.g., trip duration, age, sex) are not included in the primary analysis.

We summarized trip characteristics across adherence groups using medians with interquartile ranges for continuous variables and proportions for categorical variables.

Because individual travelers may contribute multiple trips, we used mixed-effects (multilevel) regression models with traveler identifier as a random intercept to account for within-person correlation. The primary analysis estimated the association between adherence category and post-travel composite jet-lag severity, with minimal adherence (0–2 points) as the reference group. Fixed effects included the number of time zones crossed (continuous), travel direction (eastward vs westward), and chronotype (five-level morningness–eveningness proxy). We also evaluated an interaction between adherence and chronotype to test whether the association between protocol adherence and jet-lag severity differed by morning vs evening type. Adherence was also modeled as a continuous predictor (number of points completed) to improve dose-response resolution.

To evaluate potential dose–response effects, the number of stimulated points was modeled both as an ordinal variable and as a continuous predictor. Pre-specified subgroup analyses stratified trips by travel direction and by time-zone band (1–2, 3–5, 6–8, ≥9 zones) to examine whether associations differed across travel patterns.

Several sensitivity analyses were performed to assess the robustness of the findings. First, we repeated the primary models using proportional-odds (ordinal logistic) regression for the composite jet-lag score to account for its ordinal 1–5 structure. Second, we refitted the models after excluding trips with missing or ambiguous time-zone or travel-direction information. Third, we restricted the analysis to one trip per traveler (first completed trip per device) so that observations were independent; this addresses the same repeated-measures concern via a subset analysis rather than a random effect. Fourth, we repeated the analyses after excluding trips that overlapped daylight saving time transitions where time-zone offsets are less stable.

For secondary outcomes, including individual symptom domains and anticipated versus observed symptom differences, we controlled the false discovery rate at 5% using the Benjamini–Hochberg procedure. All statistical tests were two-sided with $\alpha = 0.05$. Effect sizes (e.g., Cohen's d) are reported alongside regression estimates to facilitate clinical interpretation.

Sample size and power. Assuming a medium effect size (Cohen's $d \approx 0.5$) for differences in composite severity between high and minimal adherence groups within a given time-zone stratum, a two-sided α of 0.05 and 80% power require approximately 128 participants per group. To allow for multiple adherence categories and covariate adjustment, we targeted at least 300–400 complete trips per major subgroup (e.g., high versus minimal adherence within the 6–8 and ≥9 time-zone bands).

Analyses were conducted in R. The analysis script and an export pipeline to produce the trip-level CSV from Firestore are available on the project website (jetlagpro.com) for independent reproduction; the same pipeline is used to generate regression tables, effect sizes, and the severity-by–time-zone-and-adherence chart.

Live Dose-Response Visualization

The main analysis plots symptom severity (Y-axis) against the number of time zones crossed (X-axis). Separate lines show results for different intervention levels (e.g., number of points stimulated), with a dashed baseline line representing expected severity without any intervention.

Each data point includes:

- Mean aggregate severity (average across five symptoms)
- Standard deviation
- Standard error of the mean
- 95% confidence intervals (shown as error bars)

Two graphs present the findings.

Primary and Secondary Analyses

The primary analysis tests whether stimulating more points is associated with a reduced rise in symptoms per time zone crossed. It also explores dose-response patterns within time zone categories and compares effects for eastward vs. westward travel.

The secondary analysis checks for differences between anticipated and actual reported symptoms.

Results

The following sections are placeholders!

We are waiting on survey results from app usage. App distribution is starting in late 2025. It may take many months of use to get sufficient data to analyze. The graph shows current live data.

Placeholder text below

We analyzed data from 13 survey results and stimulation records and present that data in the graph below. We examined how different levels of acupressure stimulation affect jet lag symptoms across time zones crossed. The baseline (dashed gray line) represents expected natural jet lag severity without intervention.

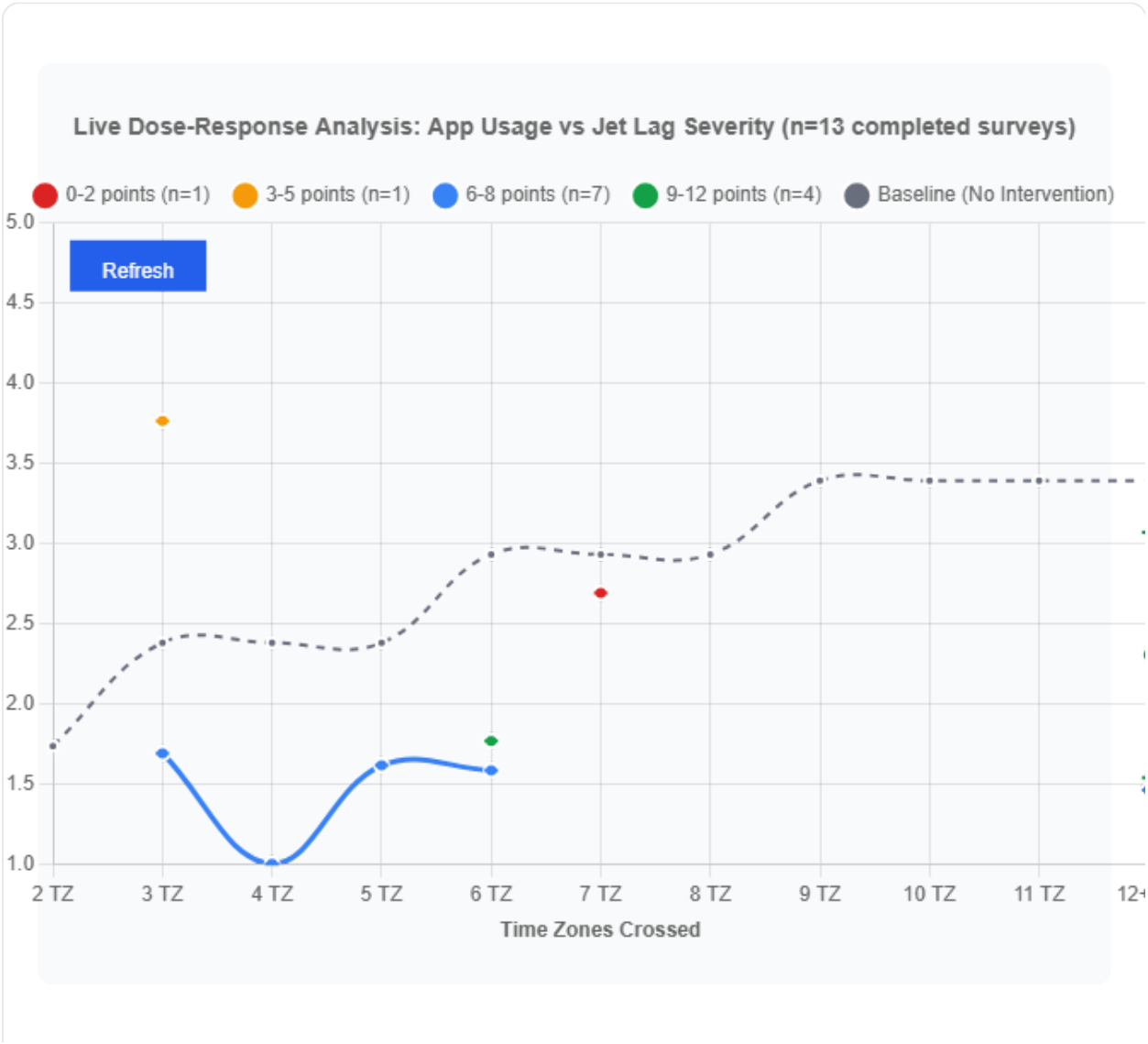


Chart Legend: *Red (0-2 points) = minimal usage, Orange (3-5 points) = low usage, Blue (6-8 points) = moderate usage, Green (9-12 points) = high usage. Error bars show ±1 standard error.*

No inferential statistics or dose–response conclusions are reported until the pre-specified sample size is reached; the current figure is for monitoring and transparency only. Currently, we have 13 data points for our graph and analysis. Until we achieve sufficient statistical power ($p < 0.05$), the results should not be considered statistically significant for reaching conclusions regarding our primary research question.

Preliminary Discussion

The proposed mechanism involves afferent pathways from somatosensory stimulation potentially influencing circadian physiology through neurohumoral pathways previously described in acupuncture research. We did not measure circadian phase or related biomarkers; proposed mechanisms remain speculative.

This paper presents a prospective observational cohort study of chronoacupuncture for jet lag in 13 long-distance travelers. Participants used the JetLagPro mobile app to self-administer acupressure at points aligned with destination time zones and completed a jet lag assessment after travel.

Confounding variables

Traditional clinical trials face significant challenges in jet lag research due to the logistical complexity of controlling travel variables, traveler demographics, and environmental factors. Our app's naturalistic data collection approach using automated, objective logging of point-stimulation timestamps and a streamlined survey based on the validated core domains of the Liverpool Jet Lag Questionnaire circumvents many of these limitations while capturing real-world efficacy across diverse travel conditions, and with large sample sizes. This design prioritizes ecological validity and scalability over experimental control reflecting how travelers actually use (or even combine) interventions in practice.

We recognize that this methodology introduces potential confounding variables, including variable traveler compliance with the protocol, possible placebo effects inherent in any tactile or app-based intervention, subjective symptom reporting with a relatively short (2-day) recall window, and the unrestricted use of concurrent strategies commonly adopted by international travelers (e.g., melatonin supplementation, strategic bright-light exposure, caffeine, meal timing or sleep hygiene adjustments). We do not collect any data on these co-interventions as the primary aim is to evaluate the app's

chronoacupuncture protocol in the context of unrestricted real-world behavior rather than isolate its effect from all other influences. Participants who complete more points may differ systematically in health behaviors and use of other interventions (e.g., melatonin, light), so we cannot separate the protocol effect from these factors (confounding by indication). We collect self-reported chronotype (morningness–eveningness) to adjust for this potential confounder and to allow exploratory subgroup and interaction analyses; chronotype is a single-item proxy rather than the full Morningness–Eveningness Questionnaire. Without sham acupressure or blinding, we cannot distinguish specific effects of meridian timing from placebo or expectation. Five classical horary points were substituted for accessibility (Table 1), so the protocol differs from horary-only protocols; this may affect effect size if point-specific timing matters.

This pragmatic approach aligns with observational studies in travel medicine, where full experimental control is often infeasible, yet large-scale, prospectively logged adherence data and patient-centered outcomes remain highly informative for hypothesis generation and future dose-response exploration. In this design, travel direction and number of time zones crossed are largely determined by the trip rather than by symptom expectations; participants do not choose them based on anticipated jet lag, which limits confounding from these covariates compared with many observational settings.

This approach may influence CDC Yellow Book guidance on jet lag which emphasizes timed light exposure, melatonin, and behavioral adjustments, with no endorsement of acupressure due to limited high-quality evidence. We address that evidence gap by providing the first prospective, large-scale dataset on a structured chronoacupuncture protocol in real-world travelers.

This study used meridian-aligned points with substitutions for accessibility (Table 1). Whether the specific point or timing is the primary driver of any benefit remains a question for future research.

Real-World Limitations and Variability

Travelers are not trained acupuncturists so point location and stimulation quality will vary during flights. Users may:

- Mark a point as done without stimulating it
- Stimulate something off-target
- Apply too little pressure or have a shortened duration
- Stimulate only one side when both sides are recommended
- Miss points (e.g., while sleeping)
- Forget to log a stimulation
- Use other remedies (e.g., melatonin, sleep adjustments)

This variability is expected and intentional in our naturalistic design. We are testing whether chronoacupressure as provided by the app is associated with benefit for the average traveler in everyday conditions, not under perfect lab-like execution. TCM theory holds that the entire meridian is active during its peak window, so even approximate or less-than-ideal stimulation at the right time and close location should still provide some benefit.

The interdisciplinary framework merging ancient temporal concepts with circadian biology creates a testable hypothesis from traditionally anecdotal practices. If validated, chronoacupuncture could provide a non-invasive, cost-effective intervention accessible to travelers without medical supervision. Negative findings would redirect research toward alternative non-photic zeitgebers and inform the scientific evaluation of other TCM temporal therapies.

Proposed Summary

Chronoacupuncture, tested via a mobile app, is being evaluated for an association between timed acupressure at meridian-aligned points and adjustment to new time zones. The technique may be associated with lower jet lag symptom severity and faster adaptation; findings are hypothesis-generating until the pre-specified sample size is reached and analyzed.

Ethics

This research was self-funded, conducted independently with no institutional affiliation, and the author declares no conflicts of interest. The study protocol qualifies for exemption under applicable frameworks for minimal-risk, self-administered behavioral research involving no more than de-identified survey and usage data. The research design posed minimal risk, as it involved self-administered acupressure, with participants free to engage at will. Survey and research data are tied only

to an untrackable device ID; participant privacy was intrinsic. Data integrity safeguards include cryptographic signatures on trip records, immutable audit logging, and publicly accessible verification tools.

Acknowledgments

Generative AI Tool Disclosure: This work utilized Cursor AI coding assistant for programming and grammar review. The AI tool performed much of the code implementation under the author's supervision and guidance. All scientific decisions, research methodology, data analysis, and interpretation were made independently by the author. Statistical analysis was aided by multiple AI's including Claude 4.5, Grok, and ChatGPT. OpenEvidence.ai was also used for feedback during manuscript preparation.

Figures and images: All point images are original creations by the author. The Chinese Organ Clock visualization (Figure 2) is an original image by the author and based on widely-used traditional representations in the public domain.

Author Biography

Steven Schram, PhD, DC, LAc is a licensed acupuncturist (1996) and chiropractor (1984) in private practice in New York City. He holds a PhD in Chemistry from the University of Maryland (1978), and holds a Doctor of Chiropractic from Life University (1983). Dr. Schram served as Assistant Professor of Research at Life University (1980-1984) and has been a peer reviewer for the World Health Organization on Traditional Medicine terminology and ICD-11 classification. He is the current Chair of the Accreditation Commission for Acupuncture and Herbal Medicine (ACAHM.ORG) and received the Lifetime Achievement Award from the Acupuncture Society of New York in 2018. Dr. Schram is also the founder and owner of Chapter 1 Software, Inc., a chiropractic practice management software company established in 1983. He has published multiple peer-reviewed articles in scientific journals spanning chemistry, chiropractic, and traditional Chinese medicine.

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